

Do only things that need effort

Simon Sure, 2 July 2026

Effort is a great proxy for what's meaningful, what leads to good, and how to get there. The effort mustn't be enormous but there needs to be resistance. Life is hard; and effort allows us to channel that hardness. Effort allows us to rid ourselves of the distractions of modern life. Effort helps us seek rest instead of cheap gratification. Altogether, doing only things that need effort makes us automatically be the person we want to be

What I mean by *things that need effort* are things that would cease happening if you would cease putting in effort
Things that need effort are unstable:

- Reading a book. You visualize how the scene looks. You must move your eyes and the book. If you're tired, you just fall asleep
- Meditation. You must notice your focus shifting and pull your attention back. Stop, and it drifts within seconds
- Going for a run. If you stop telling your body to keep moving although its exhausting, you fall
- Writing an essay. You must think about what to write, how to write. Rephrase. Restructure. Rewrite.
- Painting a picture. You must think about what to paint, how to paint, where to paint. You must prepare, buy the materials, and clean up afterwards.

Things that don't need effort are stable:

- Scrolling on Tik Tok. You can forget that you're doing it while letting hours pass by
- Daydreaming. Your brain's default mode switches on automatically the moment you stop directing attention elsewhere
- Watching TV in the evening. Your brain does less than if you were sleeping
- Ruminating or worrying. Once the loop starts, it runs in the background without you choosing to keep it going

Effort reveals the meaningful

Winning only feels great if you could have realistically lost badly. Things are only meaningful if there is an alternative scenario in which s*** hit the fan. Applying for the job is meaningful because it is possible that you won't get the job. Publishing writing/music/research is meaningful because it can be ignored and critiqued. Friendship is meaningful because you can't control betrayal of trust. Love is meaningful because it is possible to be rejected.

Facing the risk of the alternative scenario is scary. It's hard. It requires effort

Alternatively, you could derisk and vegetate through life. You could choose, whenever faced with two outcomes, one of which possibly uncomfortable, to not face that situation. This means you avoid caring. You prioritize some hypothetical risk over what is meaningful to you
That's miserable. That's rejecting life

Facing the effort means there is something you care about and you're willing to take a risk for it

Effort avoids distraction

By doing things with effort, we prevent others from stealing our time

Time is incredibly valuable and we should protect our time to be used only on what we truly care about. With unlimited time one could study 20 different subjects, become rich, excel at the Olympics, spend time with family, become literate, make friends, and everything else one might desire. But nobody has that time advantage; and, thus, we must be protective of our time

Others try to steal our time. Every distraction is someone's attempt to take a share of our time and reallocate it to a different purpose. Shifting time from you to advertisement, short-form content, the news, clickbait, toxic friends/family, etc. means giving away a part of yourself, for free

Giving away our time and being distracted is easy, convenient, and impossible if everything you do must take effort. If you want someone else's time, you make it as easy for them to give it to you. But because it's easy to scroll for hours, doesn't mean you actually want it. Distraction is easy. By building the mindset of requiring resistance at every point, you eliminate distraction from your life

Believing in doing hard things means ridding yourself of easy distraction

Choose your pain

Life is never easy; what we want never just happens. Choosing where to invest effort makes the hardship in your life a means to an end you get to choose

If you don't make something difficult, something else will be difficult. It's part of the human condition to worry, be concerned, and to struggle. If your life is great on paper, you will still find things to worry about. If you think that you can become happy by solving all the things you worry about right now, you're mistaken. If you worry about money now and you become rich, you will start stressing about investing. If you worry about being lonely now and you make friends, you will start stressing about all the drama in your friendgroup. If you worry about doing great at work now and you succeed with the current task, you will get the next bigger task the week after

By channeling your hardship, you escape perpetual worrying. There will always be worry and struggle. But you can accept and dedicate it. Then it will not cause stress but feel great. That hardship is worth it as it is exactly what you have chosen to get where you want to be

By doing things that need effort you make the struggle that's in your life anyway a tool

Effort leads to rest

Seeing that you invest effort explicitly, allows you to also see when you're tired and need rest. People who do things that do not require explicit effort, will still exhaust their energy but not realize so. They won't rest properly

You either consume energy or you replenish it. By intentionally doing things that require effort, you track how much energy you have consumed and can restore the reserves. But if you just do things without deeming them hard, they will still consume your energy. Not realizing that, you continue depleting your reserves

Doing things that are hard and require effort explicitly allows you to do hard things sustainably

Contentness and tranquility

If you follow the principle of effort, you become a person that

- (a) does only what you truly care about,
- (b) avoids distraction and builds a wall to block of negative influences, and
- (c) gives meaning to the hardship in your life.

You do all this in a way that allows you to live a stable life resistant to violent peaks of obsession and depression

In other words, you get to choose who you are. You get to be the person you choose to be. And you're at peace with it. What more can one want?